

8.3 RAM Optimisers: Are They Any Good?

There are many paid products available on the Internet that claim to optimise system RAM for better performance. Such software manipulates certain settings in the OS that deal with accessing the RAM and the virtual memory.

The pages for the most frequently used applications are kept in RAM, whereas those used not so often are kept in the page file by Windows. And virtual memory is much slower than RAM. So, applications running from virtual memory are slow, and make the system look slower.

RAM optimisers or accelerators force application to use as much RAM as possible when it is free. And some even flush redundant data out of the RAM. Theoretically, the implementation of such a tool is helpful, but how much difference will they make in current machines? Analyse this: RAM speeds are on the increase; processors and graphics cards available now are a thousand times better than what was available a few years ago; and now, both processors and motherboards have dual-channel memory architectures. If that weren't enough, you can also instruct Windows XP to limit its swap usage by editing the `system.ini` file.

The moral of the story is that memory optimisers may sound useful, but they will not effect a radical change in performance. If you think your system is slow, then you need to check the system requirements of the OS and the applications you are using. It's always better to have more than sufficient RAM. For instance, running Windows XP on 2.4 GHz system with 256 MB RAM will result in slow performance because the system memory will be used up by the OS, anti-virus and other start-up applications. So, additional applications will have to use the little space left in the RAM, or be satisfied with virtual memory. Upgrade the RAM to obtain better performance.